



Bagala's Discovery of Bengal

Bagalar Banga Darshan
Director: Ritwik Ghatak
Director of Photography:
Dilip Ranjan Mukhopadhyay
Music: Hriday Ranjan Kushari
Cast:
Sunil Bhattacharya
Indrami Mukhopadya
India 1963
36 mins
Digital

The Knave of Trumps Ranger Ghulam

India 1968
30 mins
Digital
Silent with pre-recorded sitar accompaniment by
Sheema Mukherjee

Ramkinkar Baij: A Personality Study

Ramkinkar
Director: Ritwik Ghatak
India 1975
31 mins
Digital (restoration)

Scientists of Tomorrow

Director: Ritwik Ghatak
India 1967
10 mins
Digital 4K (restoration)

The screening on Wed 3 Jun will be introduced by
season curator Sanghita Sen

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Revolutionary Cinema: The Passion of Ritwik Ghatak

Incomplete Works

Bagala's Discovery of Bengal

A comedy on mistaken identity, this film remained incomplete a week
after filming.

The Knave of Trumps

A compassionate portrait of the trials and tribulations of women in society.

Ramkinkar Baij: A Personality Study

Ghatak engages in an intimate conversation with noted Indian sculptor and
painter Ramkinkar Baij, covering the latter's art and life.

Scientists of Tomorrow

In this completed short documentary, Ghatak shines a light on the government
measures undertaken to build a robust science education in India.

Ritwik Ghatak on filmmaking

Film is, basically, a matter of personal statement. All arts are, in the final
analysis. And film seems to be an art. Only, film is a collective art. It needs
varied and numerous talent.

It does not follow that film is not personal. It may be, at one end, the case of a
collective personality, and on the other, may bear the stamp of one individual's
temperament upon all the others' creative activities.

To be art, either one or the other must be the case. Any work that lacks style
and viewpoint necessarily lacks personality – and ceases to be art.

To my mind, this is the very root of the matter. Some hodge-podge thrown
together, stylistically divergent images strung together by the device of intrigue
and 'story matter', may be a good evening's entertainment, but no sir, it is not
art. Such products abound all around us. One should resign oneself to these
sad facts of life. Sometimes one may get great pleasure out of them, but not
artistic pleasure.

That is why, even such a considerable artist as John Ford becomes
considerable only at intervals. The rest of present-day Hollywood, of course,
does not count.

I accept that these very 'story matters' and intrigues and howling good
situations are raw materials of art. But raw meat is not exactly Moghlai kebab.
A cook comes somewhere in between. A cook, that is, the artist's personality.

The moment the artist enters, things come throbbing to life. From moment to
moment, you realise with sudden shocks, that it is your innermost feelings and
unnamed eruptions that are being given voice to. You, in a word, have a
revelation.

That is why the seers of Upanishads are called poets. The poet is the
archetype of all artists. Poetry is the art of arts.

Trying to crawl back to the origins of cinema and exalting the still camera plus
motion formula are ludicrous attempts. As ludicrous, say, as trying to go back
to Dionysiac orgies and satyric mimes and masks of Thespis will be today in
matters of the stage. The same can be resolved with a sense of the

Revolutionary Cinema: The Passion of Ritwik Ghatak

The Citizen Nagarik

Mon 1 Jun 20:35; Fri 26 Jun 18:05 (+ intro by
Ashvin Devasundaram, Queen Mary University of
London)

Ritwik Ghatak Season Introduction:

A River Called Ritwik

Tue 2 Jun 18:15

The Pathetic Fallacy Ajantrik

Tue 2 Jun 20:30 (+ intro by season curator
Sanghita Sen); Sun 21 Jun 18:30

Incomplete Works

Wed 3 Jun 17:50 (+ intro by season curator
Sanghita Sen); Sat 20 Jun 18:10

Reason, Debate and a Story

Jukti Takko Aar Gappo

Wed 3 Jun 20:25 (+ intro by season curator
Sanghita Sen); Tue 30 Jun 20:40

The Traveller Musafir

Sat 6 Jun 20:10; Sun 14 Jun 18:00

Shorts and Documentaries

Sun 7 Jun 12:30; Mon 22 Jun 18:30

The Uprooted Chinnamul

Mon 8 Jun 20:35; Sat 20 Jun 12:15

Subarnarekha The Golden Line

Wed 10 Jun 20:25; Sun 28 Jun 12:00

(+ pre-recorded intro)

The Cloud-Capped Star Meghe Dhaka Tara

Thu 11 Jun 18:00 (+ intro by Manishita Dass, author

of *BFI Film Classic: The Cloud-Capped Star*);

Sat 27 Jun 14:40

A River Called Titas Titash Ekti Nadir Naam

Sat 13 Jun 14:20 (+ intro by Tanjil Rashid, Culture

Editor at the *New Statesman*); Sun 28 Jun 14:50

E-Flat Komol Gandhar

Sat 13 Jun 20:20; Sat 27 Jun 17:30

(+ pre-recorded intro)

The Runaway Bari Theke Paliye

Wed 17 Jun 18:00 (+ intro by Agni Lahiri, film

protagonist's son and producer's grandson);

Sat 27 Jun 12:10

The Diamond Butterfly Heerer Prajapati

Sun 21 Jun 15:15; Sun 28 Jun 18:15

In partnership with



On the birth centenary of Ritwik Ghatak, NFDC-NFAI carried out unprecedented digital preservation of his entire filmography including feature length films, numerous shorts, documentaries and unfinished works, all under the National Film Heritage Mission. The eight features have been restored in 4K from various film elements preserved by NFDC-NFAI and West Bengal State Film Archive, with colour grading supervised by renowned Indian cinematographer Avik Mukhopadhyay.

contemporary, of course, but in a synthesis on a higher level, such as *Strange Interlude* of O'Neill or Strindberg's *Dream Play*, or more aptly in Brecht's experimentation. *Organon* remains the most brilliant attempt at such a synthesis.

And that is precisely what is happening in the hands of all the masters of cinema, from Flaherty down to Fellini and Antonioni. My first film was called a picaresque episodic film along the lines of the 18th-century Spanish novel *Gil Bias De Santillane*, the second was called a film of documentary approach, the next was a melodrama, and the fourth nothing at all, just no film.

To my mind, I am only groping. Groping to find the most proper expression for the theme at hand. Sometimes I may have connected, sometimes gone wide of the mark. I have tried to experiment with forms of story, treatment, styles of taking, images etc. Each one of my films is quite different from the others, though I fear my personality and inclinations are in all of them. From the compositional point of view, all the films have divergent balancing principles thought to be inherent in the theme. In the soundtracks, including the music, I have tried to weave different patterns.

It is the nuances I am after, the elusive, fleeting nuances. They contain the life-spark.

Any story is good material if it contains the scope for those nuances, even the songs and dances are not loads around your neck. They are creative elements with tremendous potentials, if the theme and approach calls for them.

There are so many genres. One accepts melodrama as one. I do not believe in the film's privileges being turned into dogma (a la Dr Kracauer). I do not abhor abstraction, scientific or otherwise. I believe in organising my filmic elements, even if one wants to catch and portray the very flow of life itself.

I do feel a quickening of heart when the camera shows the instantaneous, the casual, the proverbial ripples in the water, the everyday glory of a sunset, or an involuntary twitching of a pain-stricken face. But I do not know out of hand the passions of an Othello or a drunken clown's tirade about life to a ballerina who is sick at heart.

I think a truly national cinema will emerge from the much abused form of melodrama when truly serious and considerate artists will bring the pressure of their entire intellect upon it. After all Mizoguchi and Kurosawa and Kinugasa took the Noh and Kabuki in their hands and squeezed supremely personal statements out of them.

The prospect is exciting, is it not?

Ritwik Ghatak, 'The Film and I', *Montage* vol. 2 no. 3 (1963)

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